The third aspect of this relationship was that despite partnering because of a 'common enemy', India and the UF were on separate strategic wavelengths. The UF's primary motive was to defeat the Taliban, which meant countering Pakistan. India's motive was to undercut Pakistan's influence by actively supporting any group that was willing to fight the Taliban. That Pakistan provided military supplies to the Taliban was an open secret. This time, however, under the watch of the Taliban, Pakistan had placed its own soldiers on Afghan soil to defeat the UF.[43] This fact played a critical role in tipping the balance in favour of the partisans over the conciliators. Of interest here is the duality of India's approach. Despite the MEA's official line of a stable Afghanistan and non-interference from external players, there was a silent under-current in India's security establishment that viewed Afghanistan as Pakistan's Vietnam and preferred the Pakistan army to get bogged down.[44] According to Major General (Retd.) Yeshwant Deva, this was so because 'Pashtuns within the Pakistan army, who have family ties in Afghanistan, would want it to become more engaged.'[45] More so, he continued, Pakistan would like to maintain some control over the Taliban (using its Pashtun-based 'Frontier Corps').[46] Neither was this approach novel to India's Afghanistan policy, nor subdued in popular narrative. In fact, according to Pramit Pal Chaudhuri, former member of India's National Security Advisory Board (NSAB) and a strategic affairs editor at the Hindustan Times, 'ultimately the game is how do you make Afghans strong enough to fight Pakistan or to bleed Pakistan inside Afghanistan … If Pakistan were to be bogged down, it will be fine by us. And we will get another five to ten years of relative peace on our border with Pakistan.'[47] By this logic, it was in India's interest to keep the UF afloat but not too strong. The UF on the other hand, wanted an end to the conflict and full control over Afghanistan.

To be clear, there are multiple discourses on India's covert military support to the UF even today. According to Shyam Saran, India 'saw its interest in supporting the Northern Alliance. Not only supporting in political terms but also providing material and even military support.'[48] A host of former Indian diplomatic and intelligence officers, as well as Afghan officials close to Massoud in the 1990s corroborate India's involvement in the military sphere.[49]